



SDRP: SETTLER & INDIGENOUS COMMS

TWO YEARS AFTER KAMLOOPS, A REPORT

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9202, 13 April 2024

OVERVIEW

This report analyzes the communication strategies employed in response to the discovery of unmarked graves at the Kamloops Residential School in the summer of 2021.

It analyzes the comms strategies of the Tkemlúps te Secwépemc First Nation (TTFN) and various settler institutions represented by the BC Provincial Government, the Canadian Federal Government, and the University of Fraser Valley. It highlights the contrasting approaches taken by settler and Indigenous media in framing the crisis.

This analysis hinges on three key aspects of communication: firstly, assessing how each entity communicated and whether they took responsibility for their actions. Secondly, exploring how each party framed the situation, either through the emphasis on factual details or by centring on the emotional impact of the tragedy. Thirdly and finally, this report will analyze the pledges and promises made by different entities, how they were communicated and what has been accomplished so far.

The report will specifically analyze the press reports released by the Tkemlúps te Secwépemc and Settler institutions represented by the B.C. government, the Federal government, and media such as the CBC. It will also look at the various statements and promises made in the following weeks and months from both Settler entities and Indigenous entities, comparing their messaging and finally discussing whether those promises have been kept.

Other products that will be analyzed include a statement made by the Federal government on May 2021, the government's decision to observe the National Day for Truth and Reconciliation on September 30, a report made by the Office of the Special Interlocuter in June of 2023 (which represents the most recent update), only to name a few.

Ultimately, the goal here is to summarize the events that unfolded nearly three years ago at Kamloops, recognize the strengths and weaknesses in how this crisis was communicated by both sides and develop recommendations to improve communication approaches in similar situations moving forward.

BACKGROUND & TIMELINE

On May 27, 2021, an event transpired that had a tremendous effect on Canadian society. On that day three years ago, the Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc nation released a press report by their Chief, Rosanne Casimir, confirming the finding of the remains of 215 children at the site of the former Kamloops Residential School. Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc is a First Nations government that represents ten out of seventeen Secwepemc band governments, its primary reserve is located adjacent to the town of Kamloops and is named Kamloops Indian Reserve 1.

The press report detailed the harrowing news of how their Language and Culture Department made the discovery: through the use of ground-penetrating radar and collaboration with “ceremonial Knowledge Keepers” (researchers from the University of Fraser Valley). The following quote was included in the initial press release: We had a knowing in our community that we were able to verify.

“To our knowledge, these missing children are undocumented deaths,” stated Kukpi7 (Chief) Rosanne Casimir. “Some were as young as three years old. We sought out a way to confirm that knowing out of deepest respect and love for those lost children and their families, understanding that Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc is the final resting place of these children.”

The reaction and response were almost immediate, hundreds of articles began pouring out demanding answers concerning these unmarked graves and the alleged deaths of over 200 children. Settler institutions and media would begin releasing statements over the following days.

Timeline

On May 28, the Premier of British Columbia, John Horgan, released his statement regarding the news of the unmarked sites. The B.C. government's press report emphasized the loss of life and the dark history of the country concerning the treatment of Indigenous people. Thoughts were placed with the community and resources such as a crisis hotline for Residential School survivors were referenced.

On that same day, the Federal government released their statement issued by the Minister of Crown-Indigenous Relations and the Minister of Indigenous Services, the Honorable Carolyn Bennett and the Honourable Marc Miller respectively. This press report, similar to the B.C. government's report, emphasized the tragedy and the deaths of the children and referred to Canada's dark past with the Residential School system. The report went on to mention current efforts to work with the Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc and the provincial government to provide resources and support as determined by the community. The Federal government further highlighted the efforts of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) to list specific actions to redress the legacy of residential schools and advance the process of Canadian reconciliation, as well as the National Centre for Truth and Reconciliation that is responsible for the collection of data for Student Death Registries. The report ends with links and references to sources to support those in crisis.

From the side of settler media, one of the most read articles and the one that I saw during that period was a CBC article that was published on the 28th of May, titled: “Remains of 215 children found buried at former B.C. residential school, First Nation says.” This article by Courtney Dickson summarizes the findings of the First Nation community and the efforts of the research team to utilize ground-penetrating radar to survey the unmarked sites. It includes statements from multiple Indigenous entities, such as the Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc, the Union of British Columbia Indian

Chiefs (UBCIC) and the First Nations Health Authority (FNHA) to name a few. The article also provides more details and information on the Kamloops Residential School. For example, researchers believe that around five hundred students attended the school, which operated from 1890 to 1969 when the Federal government took over administration from the Catholic Church. It would finally close in 1978. Furthermore, as of the establishment of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission in 2008, 'only' fifty deaths had been recorded at the school. Overall, the article has a major emphasis on Indigenous voices and includes links and references to resources to support anyone in crisis.

So far, everything that has been listed only covers the first two days of the crisis and over the following weeks, the statements and findings from both Settler and Indigenous institutions would evolve. More and more outcries would grow as Canadians began demanding answers. Many were shocked that a tragedy of this scale could happen or at least that it would remain hidden for so long. Talks would take place between the various communities in the Kamloops region and the Settler governments, a big update wouldn't come until July of that same year.

In July of 2021, the University of Fraser Valley published its findings concerning the Kamloops Residential School Site. Dr. Sarah Beaulieu, an anthropologist from the University presented a summary of her ground-penetrating radar investigation. Beaulieu's work indeed confirmed the probable unmarked graves on the grounds of the former school. The report summarizes that radar is not the only means to confirm the deaths and that other tools are available to Indigenous communities to confirm their findings – these tools or alternative strategies are not listed nor are they given an explanation. From there, the Canadian Public was convinced, and demands would be made to the government in response to the news. In August of 2021, the Federal government would release a follow-up statement. This statement was highly important as it made several promises and assertions. Firstly, approximately \$320 million in additional support for Indigenous-led, Survivor-centric and culturally informed initiatives and investments were promised.

Here is the financial breakdown from the Federal Government's website: (Of this funding,) \$83 million will supplement existing investments for community-led processes to research and locate burial sites as well as to commemorate and memorialize the children who died at residential schools. These resources are in addition to the \$27.1 million which is part of the \$33.8 million committed in Budget 2019 to implement the Truth and Reconciliation Commission Calls to Action 72 to 76, bringing the Government of Canada's commitment to \$116.8 million to support this important work.

Additionally, the government promised the creation of a National Advisory Committee to advise communities and the government on the work to locate burial sites. From the news release: "In consultation with National Indigenous Organizations, the Committee will consist of Indigenous knowledge holders and experts in areas such as archaeology, forensics, pathology and mental health." Even more funding is promised to commemorate the history and ongoing legacy of Residential Schools and their survivors. To support these efforts, the government announced \$9.6 million over three years in addition to \$13.4 million over five years. A further \$20 million in new funding will be set aside to build a national monument in Ottawa to honour Residential School survivors. Finally, a Special Interlocutor will be selected by the Minister of Justice and the Attorney General, who will work with Indigenous Peoples, provincial and territorial governments, and communities to identify needed measures and make recommendations relating to federal laws, regulations, policies, and practices surrounding unmarked and undocumented graves and burial sites at residential schools.

The Federal government did not stop at only financial promises. In June of 2021 Bill C-5 passed into law which created a new national holiday, the National Day for Truth and Reconciliation to be observed on September 30. This day was set aside to honour and commemorate the survivors and those who did not survive the residential school system. And on September 30, 2021, the first-ever

National Day of Truth and Reconciliation was observed. Orange shirts are also meant to be worn on that day. This action had a huge impact on Canadian society and forced many conversations concerning the Residential School system and the treatment of Indigenous peoples throughout many facets of Canadian society. I remember reconciliation being a huge topic during that year. Equally, that year, Western University and many other post-secondary institutions would formally adopt the land acknowledgment. More anecdotally, many more professors at Western would introduce their classes with the land acknowledgment, at least on the very first day of the course. Ultimately, the news of the Kamloops graves and the resulting response and reactions catalyzed huge changes in Canadian society.

Now jumping forward, a couple of months or so. The CBC announced a major monetary settlement reached during a class action lawsuit over residential schools. On January 21, 2023, the Federal government agreed to pay \$2.8 billion in reparations to 325 First Nations, seeking reparations for the loss of language and culture as a result of the Residential School system. Marc Miller, the Minister for Crown-Indigenous Relations had this to say: "While settlements like those announced today ... do not make up for the past, what it can do is address the collective harm caused by Canada's past, [...] The loss of language, the loss of culture and heritage." Again, the government emphasizes the loss of life and the damages caused by Settler-Indigenous relations throughout Canadian history. Though the article details that the class action lawsuit was filed before the announcement of the unmarked graves at Kamloops, it is speculated that the news persuaded the government to seek a financial settlement sooner rather than later. It is also an excellent means for the government to build positive PR, as this decision would likely be viewed as another means of the government supporting Indigenous communities and reconciling from the horrors of the past.

The final updates concerning the Kamloops Residential School come from June and December of last year. The Office of the Independent Special Interlocutor, a position created by the Federal government tasked with advising and making recommendations on ways to improve the legal process to identify and protect unmarked graves, released its Interim report in June of 2023. This report identifies recurring concerns expressed by the survivors and families regarding the search and recovery efforts of unmarked graves or unaccounted bodies. Based on these concerns, the report presents 48 findings related to legal limitations and a lack of allocated resources for the efforts of identification and recovery. The report dedicates a section to the Kamloops Residential School and provides no new updates concerning the unmarked sites. It does, however, make recommendations for legal changes to support Indigenous communities and leadership to survey and maintain any future sites that might be found.

The final report comes from the Assembly of First Nations and was published in December of 2023. This report quickly summarizes the history of Residential Schools in Canada and provides updates on the Kamloops Residential School site. Like the Interim report, conclusions lie with the findings from ground penetrating radar, however, the site has not been further surveyed and no details are given. The report has a greater emphasis on reconciliation and the steps going forward. The Assembly of First Nations highlights several key issues, such as the repudiation of the Doctrine of Discovery by the Vatican in March 2023, a proposal to support a national committee focused on Calls to Action related to missing children and burial information. Finally, the report criticizes the slow progress of the implementation of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission, emphasizing the greater need for culturally appropriate healing support for Indigenous communities.

As of April 2024, The Canadian Federal government and other Settler institutions continue to promise support towards reconciliation efforts. The tragedy surrounding the Kamloops Residential School and its bombshell announcement to the world had a significant impact on Canadian society and is a great example of the strategies employed for crisis communications by different sides.

The Takeaways

In summary, we can identify five key takeaways, that will be expanded upon in the next section, from this situation and from the events listed in our timeline.

- Firstly, the discovery of unmarked graves at the Kamloops Residential School forced Canadians to confront the dark history of the residential school system and its horrifying impact on Indigenous communities. The discovery ignited national outrage, massive media coverage and international attention.
- Secondly, settler intuitions such as the Canadian Federal government responded with financial commitments, the creation of a National Day for Truth and Reconciliation and the development of several initiatives to support survivors and their communities. Unfortunately, concerns remain regarding the pace of reconciliation efforts as highlighted by the Special Interlocutor and the Assembly of First Nations.
- Thirdly, the Kamloops crisis highlighted the importance of Indigenous voices in shaping the narrative. The Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc First Nation led the way in uncovering the truth and advocating for their community. Settler's media coverage also prioritized Indigenous perspectives.
- Fourthly, the discovery at Kamloops has spurred a renewed focus on commitments between government institutions and Indigenous communities, several positions were created as well as many federal commissions to support ongoing reconciliation efforts.
- Finally, legal limitations and a lack of resources hinder efforts to identify and protect unmarked graves. The final status of the Kamloops Residential School site remains unclear, with no new updates on further investigation or identification of remains.

In the next section, we will more specifically look at the differences or similarities in framing between Indigenous and Settler institutions, to develop a better understanding of communications practices, both best practices and possible lessons learned.

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Statement on the discovery around Kamloops Indian Residential School

From: [Crown-Indigenous Relations and Northern Affairs Canada](#)

Statement

Ottawa, Ontario (May 28, 2021) — The Honourable Carolyn Bennett, Minister of Crown-Indigenous Relations, and the Honourable Marc Miller, Minister of Indigenous Services, issued the following statement today:

“The mistreatment of Indigenous children is a tragic and shameful part of Canada’s history. Residential schools were part of a colonial policy that removed Indigenous children from their communities. Thousands of children were sent to these schools and never returned to their families. The families were often provided with little to no information on the circumstances of their loved one’s death nor the location of their burial. Children in residential schools were forbidden to speak their language and practice their own culture. The loss of children who attended residential schools is unthinkable and Canada remains resolved to supporting families, Survivors and communities and to memorializing those lost innocent souls.

FRAMING OF THE CRISIS

Indigenous entities, we shall look at the initial response to the crisis. Though both groups demonstrated sympathetic and emotional weight upon the discovery, there are some key differences to note. The press reports released by the Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc, the B.C. government, the Federal government and a CBC article will be used to evidence this analysis.

In general, both sides immediately acknowledged the tragedy and Canada's dark history with residential schools. They focused heavily on the emotional weight of the discovery and the value of human life. Equally, all three provide references to forms of support and help in some manner or other. Let us now look more specifically at these examples.

Settler Framing

Settler entities, while acknowledging the tragedy, initially focused on factual details. Press releases mentioned the number of graves found and placed the event in a historical context. Press reports were structured in much of the same way, an opener addressing the tragedy and deaths of 215 children, another paragraph addressing the historic context of residential schools and the ongoing trauma resulting from this, a promise of support and commitment to Indigenous communities and finally links or references to resources people can use.

The B.C. Premier's statement, "Premier's statement about burial site at former Kamloops Indian Residential School" is a lot more personalized as it opens with the personal pronoun "I". "I am horrified and heartbroken to learn that the burial site of 215 children has been confirmed on the grounds of the former Kamloops Indian Residential School. I honour Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc as they grapple with this burden from a dark chapter of Canadian history and uphold their commitment to complete this investigation over the coming weeks – bringing to light the full truth of this loss." In this context, John Horgan is attempting to frame himself as supportive of the community and in utter emotional disbelief at the news. It also mentions "a dark chapter" in Canadian history, which limits the effects of the residential schools to the past. The schools may have disappeared, but the scars certainly have not. The statement also lacks any mention of working with or seeking to directly support Indigenous communities in B.C. or even in the Kamloops region. This is rather different than the Federal government's press release.

Unlike, what was published by the province the federal government's statement lacks a personal character. "The Statement on the Discovery Around Kamloops Indian Residential School" is a few paragraphs longer than the previous press report and contains more information.

For example, within the second paragraph after listing a historical summary of the residential school system, the new release says this: "We are working with the community and our partners, such as the BC First Nations Health Authority, to provide resources and the support needed as determined by the community." Furthermore, the press release emphasizes the factual aspects of the government's commitment to reconciliation. It names the TRC and its creation, lists exact numbers for calls of action and lists several contacts in the government who can be reached for further questions. In some ways, this framing allows the government to distance itself from the past and highlight the efforts they have made for reconciliation and the betterment of Indigenous-Settler relations. Now looking at the CBC article "Remains of 215 children found buried at former B.C. residential school, First Nation says,". This article is more balanced in its framing of events. Like other Settler media, it does demonstrate sympathy but is highly based on factual evidence and numbers. For

example, it provides the number of students that attended the school and the history of the school with dates:

“The Kamloops Indian Residential School was in operation from 1890 to 1969, when the federal government took over administration from the Catholic Church to operate it as a residence for a day school, until closing in 1978. Up to 500 students would have been registered at the school, according to the National Centre for Truth and Reconciliation (NCTR). Those children would have come from First Nations communities across B.C. and beyond.”

However, the article does make a noticeable effort to prioritize Indigenous voices and the majority of the information presented comes from Indigenous sources. For example, it includes statements from the First Nations Health Authority and the Union of British Columbia Indian Chiefs which emphasized the pain and trauma felt from this tragedy. The inclusion of Indigenous voices ensured a more complete narrative emerged, offering a glimpse into the diverse experiences and perspectives within Indigenous communities. However, simply including Indigenous voices during moments of crisis isn't sufficient. It can't be a performative act of tokenism or as a means to please the crowd.

Quotes

Press Release B.C

- “I am horrified and heartbroken to learn that the burial site of 215 children has been confirmed on the grounds of the former Kamloops Indian Residential School. I honour Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc as they grapple with this burden from a dark chapter of Canadian history and uphold their commitment to complete this investigation over the coming weeks – bringing to light the full truth of this loss.”
- “Each child has been forever taken from a family and a community that loved them. This is a tragedy of unimaginable proportions. And it is a stark example of the violence the Canadian residential school system inflicted upon Indigenous peoples and how the consequences of these atrocities continue to this day.”
- “My thoughts are with the Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc and all who mourn, as they enact their cultural protocols to notify First Nations communities whose children were sent to this school.”

Federal Press Release

- “The mistreatment of Indigenous children is a tragic and shameful part of Canada's history. Residential schools were part of a colonial policy that removed Indigenous children from their communities. Thousands of children were sent to these schools and never returned to their families.”
- “We are working with the community and our partners, such as the BC First Nations Health Authority, to provide resources and the support needed as determined by the community. For immediate assistance to those who may need it, the National Indian Residential School Crisis Line is available 24 hours a day at 1-866-925-4419.”
- “The TRC revealed the heartbreaking details of the role that residential schools played in the history of Canada and the tragic legacy that continues today. It is said that once you know the truth, you cannot unknow it. Yesterday's discovery reflects a dark and painful chapter in our country's history. We remain committed to supporting Survivors, their families and communities through their healing journeys.”

Ultimately, Settler entities, including governments and media, initially focused on factual details. Press releases outlined the number of graves discovered and provided historical context. While crucial, this objective framing risked creating emotional distance. It presented the tragedy as a historical footnote, not a raw wound. Here, the focus was on delivering information, not igniting a national reckoning.

Indigenous Framing

The Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc First Nation was the first organization/group to release the news of the unmarked graves at the Kamloops residential school.

Their press release wasn't a dry recitation of facts unlike what was seen with Settler media. The press release doesn't sensationalize the discovery. Instead, it frames it as a confirmation of a long-held "knowing" within the community. Phrases like "unthinkable loss" and "students of the Kamloops Indian Residential School" establish the context and gravity of the situation. Chief Rosanne Casimir is the primary voice throughout, emphasizing the community's responsibility as "the final resting place of these children." Words like "respect" and "love" highlight the emotional weight of the discovery for the community.

The press release also acknowledges the "effects of residential school" on the community, ensuring the audience understands the discovery's significance beyond just the number of graves. Furthermore, phrases like "still developing" and "more questions than answers" reflect the ongoing nature of the investigation and the community's struggle for closure. In general, the press release outlines the steps taken and has a heavy focus on transparency: "This is the beginning but, given the nature of this news, we felt it important to share immediately. At this time, we have more questions than answers. We look forward to providing updates as they become available."

The Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc press release frames reconciliation through transparency. Prioritizing communication with their community demonstrates respect for those directly affected. Outlining specific next steps, such as "engaging with the coroner" and "seeking out any existing records," fosters trust and accountability. Notably, the press release avoids dwelling solely on the past. Phrases like "seeking peace and closure" and "acknowledgement of the effects of residential school" shift the focus from just the number of graves to the ongoing impact and the need for healing. This reframing positions the discovery as a catalyst for reconciliation efforts. The Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc press release stands in stark contrast to a potential Settler media framing that might solely focus on blame. Instead, the language used emphasizes the human cost. Terms like "missing students" and "lost loved ones" highlight the human tragedy rather than solely pointing fingers. Similarly, phrases like "seeking peace and closure" and "the beginning" acknowledge the historical trauma but frame the discovery as a step towards reconciliation, not just dwelling on the past.

Quotes

- "We had a knowing in our community that we were able to verify. To our knowledge, these missing children are undocumented deaths," stated Kukpi7 Rosanne Casimir. "Some were as young as three years old. We sought out a way to confirm that knowing out of deepest respect and love for those lost children and their families, understanding that Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc is the final resting place of these children."
- We are thankful for the Pathway to Healing grant we received to undertake this important work. Given the size of the school, with up to 500 students registered and attending at any one time, we understand that this confirmed loss affects First Nations communities across British Columbia and beyond. We wish to ensure that our community members, as well as all home communities for the children who attended, are duly informed. This is the beginning but, given the nature of this news, we felt it important to share immediately. At this time we have more questions than answers. We look forward to providing updates as they become available."

Overall, Indigenous media utilizes a victim-centred framing strategy. It focuses on the human cost of the residential school system, emphasizing the ongoing trauma for Indigenous communities. By

prioritizing Indigenous voices, cultural sensitivity, and transparency, the Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc First Nation effectively shapes the narrative around the discovery and adds a personal character that is missing within Settler media.

Framing Conclusions

In the end, I found that there were four key differences or similarities between Indigenous and Settler media, and they can be summarized as the following:

- Firstly, settler media focuses on factual details, the historical context and generally distancing from the emotional impact while on the Indigenous side, things like the human cost, ongoing trauma and the emotional weight of the tragedy are more important.
- Secondly, there are key differences in the language and tone used; an objective and impersonal one vs a victim-centered mentality.
- Thirdly, in terms of transparency, settler media is limited in detail on the next steps and heavily focuses on past efforts in reconciliation. Indigenous media is completely different in this regard, as they prioritize community needs first and focus on future efforts rather than blame for the past.
- Fourthly and finally, and still related to the last point, Settlers are focused on a dark past or the mistakes of the past versus the Indigenous mentality of looking at tragedies as a catalyst for future healing.

Though I must acknowledge that both entities attempt to acknowledge the tragedy, they add emotional weight to the event, they offer support in some capacity and they both acknowledge the undeniable and necessary historical context of residential schools.

It should be noted that either side published their press releases on their respective websites, through their socials and primarily through legacy-media outlets such as the CBC and Global News.



Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc

(Kamloops Indian Band)

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

May 27, 2021, Kamloops – It is with a heavy heart that Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc Kukpi7 (Chief) Rosanne Casimir confirms an unthinkable loss that was spoken about but never documented by the Kamloops Indian Residential School. This past weekend, with the help of a ground penetrating radar specialist, the stark truth of the preliminary findings came to light – the confirmation of the remains of 215 children who were students of the Kamloops Indian Residential School.

Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc is the home community of the Kamloops Indian Residential School which was the largest school in the Indian Affairs residential school system. As such, Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc Leadership acknowledges their responsibility to caretake for these lost children.

"We had a knowing in our community that we were able to verify. To our knowledge, these missing children are undocumented deaths," stated Kukpi7 Rosanne Casimir. "Some were as young as three years old. We sought out a way to confirm that knowing out of deepest respect and love for those lost children and their families, understanding that Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc is the final resting place of these children."

This work was undertaken by the C7élksteñs re Secwépemc ne Ckúhtens ell ne Xqwel'téns (Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc Language and Culture Department) with ceremonial Knowledge Keepers who ensured that the work was conducted respectfully in light of the serious nature of the investigation with cultural protocols being upheld.

Given that these lost loved ones are buried within the Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc community, and with all community members still grappling with the effects of residential school, Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc Chief and Council first reached out to their community members to make them aware of the situation, albeit that it is still developing.

Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc will continue to work with the ground penetrating radar specialist to complete the survey of the former Kamloops Indian Residential School grounds. In undertaking this current investigation, Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc Chief and Council would like to acknowledge the preliminary work that was carried out in the early 2000's. With access to the latest technology, the true accounting of the missing students will hopefully bring some peace and closure to those lives lost and their home communities.

Kukpi7 Rosanne Casimir stated, "We are thankful for the Pathway to Healing grant we received to

PROMISES OF ACTION OR SUPPORT

As has been noted through this analysis, several promises were made primarily by the Canadian Federal government in response to the Kamloops crisis. To summarize these promises of action and support we will look at the Federal news release published on August 10, 2021.

Overall, the document acknowledges the need for emotional and cultural support for survivors of residential schools and their families. However, its effectiveness is hampered by a lack of specifics. It mentions "existing programs" such as the Indian Residential School Survivors Support Program but it fails to elaborate on how these programs might be enhanced to address the vast scope of intergenerational trauma. Without such details, the promise of "support" remains a vague notion, leaving survivors and their families with unanswered questions about the actual resources available to help them heal.

- "We will continue to work with Indigenous Survivors, families, communities and leaders, to ensure that there is justice for all the children who never made it home. We need to act now to ensure the human rights of Indigenous Peoples are respected."
- David T. Lametti, Minister of Justice and Attorney General of Canada

Financial Support & Monetary Backing

However, one concrete step forward is the pledge of \$320 million in additional support for Indigenous-led, Survivor-centric and culturally informed initiatives and investments to help Indigenous communities respond to and heal from the ongoing impacts of residential schools. An additional \$33.8 million has been committed to support the identification and commemoration of unmarked burial sites. This commitment signifies an attempt to finally uncover the truth about the atrocities committed within the residential school system. The document includes a quick breakdown of the funding and its uses, included here:

"Of this funding, \$83 million will supplement existing investments for community-led processes to research and locate burial sites as well as to commemorate and memorialize the children who died at residential schools. These resources are in addition to the \$27.1 million which is part of the \$33.8 million committed in Budget 2019 to implement the Truth and Reconciliation Commission Calls to Action 72 to 76, bringing the Government of Canada's commitment to \$116.8 million to support this important work."

However, the document lacks details on how these funds will be distributed and managed. Will Indigenous communities have a direct role in overseeing the process of locating unmarked graves? The document offers no such assurance, raising concerns about potential top-down approaches that might exclude the very communities most affected. For instance, a more impactful communication strategy would have outlined a collaborative framework where Indigenous knowledge holders and traditional burial practices are respected and integrated into the identification process.

Another significant action is the establishment of a National Day for Truth and Reconciliation. This national acknowledgement, set for September 30th each year, serves as a public reminder of the residential school system's legacy. The document mentions educational resources and community events but fails to delve deeper into how these initiatives will be developed and implemented. They could have outlined a plan for creating educational resources in collaboration with Indigenous educators, ensuring their accuracy and sensitivity. Furthermore, it also could have detailed a funding stream dedicated to supporting community-led events that reflect the unique traditions and perspectives of each Indigenous nation.

Tone, Style, and Language

In terms of tone and style of language, the document relies heavily on formal language, a characteristic feature of government comms. While this sort of language and tone can convey authority, it also creates a barrier for some audiences. Terms like "ongoing impacts" and "enhanced support" lack the emotional weight needed to truly connect with the gravity of the situation. For instance, instead of simply mentioning "emotional support," the document could have acknowledged the widespread mental health issues faced by survivors and their families, committing to increased funding for culturally relevant trauma therapy programs. Furthermore, a transparent plan detailing how the allocated funds will be used for locating unmarked graves and holding the government accountable for its promises would be a strong addition. The document mentions "supporting Indigenous communities" but lacks specifics on how these funds will be distributed or managed. Outlining a clear distribution process with a detailed oversight plan would build trust with Indigenous communities who have historically faced broken promises from the Canadian government.

While the document represents a tentative step towards acknowledging the trauma caused by the residential school system, it lacks the level of detail and transparency needed to fully assess the government's commitment. Moving forward, specific plans grounded in collaboration with Indigenous communities, clear communication that speaks to the emotional weight of the issue and a genuine dialogue with Indigenous voices will be vital factors in determining whether these promises are fulfilled.

Timeline of Promises: Fulfilled and Unfulfilled

I have included here a breakdown based on my research and available resources from the Government of Canada website and news published on the CBC. Overall, the majority of promises have yet to be fulfilled and for the most part, it is difficult to accurately determine where these funds have gone and if the necessary programs or communities have received them.

Besides the announcement of the \$2.8 billion settlement, no exact figures can be found regarding monetary allotments. Answers might have been found if interviews had been conducted, however, this is a topic that will be handled in the following sections.

Fulfilled

- 1) The report announces \$83 million to supplement existing investments for community-led processes to research and locate burial sites as well as commemorate and memorialize the children who died at residential schools.

Fulfillment Status: Partially fulfilled. While the initial funding was announced in 2021, it's difficult to say definitively if all the funds have been distributed and used by communities.

- 2) It mentions establishing a National Day for Truth and Reconciliation on September 30th.

Fulfillment Status: Fulfilled. The first National Day for Truth and Reconciliation was observed on September 30, 2021.

- 3) The report promises additional funding for mental health, culture, and emotional support services for Survivors and their families. This includes renewing existing programs and expanding services.

Fulfillment Status: Partially fulfilled. Similar to the funding for burial sites, the report was from 2021. While the initial investment was announced, it's unclear if all the funds have been distributed and used for expanded services.

- 4) It announces the appointment of a Special Interlocutor to work with Indigenous communities and governments on unmarked and undocumented graves.

Fulfillment Status: Fulfilled. On June 8, 2022, Kimberly Murray was appointed as an Independent Special Interlocutor for Missing Children and Unmarked Graves and Burial Sites associated with Indian Residential Schools

- 5) It mentions establishing a National Advisory Committee to advise communities and the government on locating burial sites. Fulfillment Status: Fulfilled. In July 2022, the National Advisory Committee on Residential Schools Missing Children and Unmarked Burials was established.

Ongoing Fulfillment

- 6) The report pledges \$100.1 million over two years to support community plans for managing residential school buildings. This could include demolition, rehabilitation, or new construction.

Fulfillment Status: Ongoing. The timeframe for this funding is two years, so depending on when it was announced in 2021, some communities may have begun using these funds, but it's likely not a completed initiative. Information not available.

- 7) The report promises \$20 million for a national monument in Ottawa to honour Survivors and the children taken from their families.

Fulfillment Status: Ongoing. This is a significant project and is likely in the planning stages. There would be design considerations, construction timelines, etc.

The screenshot shows the BC Government website. At the top is the BC logo and 'BRITISH COLUMBIA'. Below is a search bar and navigation links: Home, Ministries, Sectors, Connect, Subscribe, News Archive. The main heading is 'Office of the Premier'. The article title is 'Premier's statement about burial site at former Kamloops Indian Residential School'. There is a 'Share' section with social media icons. The 'Statement' section includes the date 'Friday, May 28, 2021 9:10 AM'. The 'Media Contacts' section lists Lindsay Byers, Press Secretary, Deputy Communications Director, Office of the Premier, with email Lindsay.Byers@gov.bc.ca. The 'Meet the Team' section lists Cabinet Ministers, Deputy Ministers, and Cabinet Committees. The 'More from the' section is partially visible. The article text begins with 'Premier John Horgan has issued the following statement about the burial site at the former Kamloops Indian Residential School:'. The statement text is partially visible, starting with 'I am horrified and heartbroken to learn that the burial site of 215 children has been confirmed on the grounds of the former Kamloops Indian Residential School. I honour Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc as they grapple with this burden from a dark chapter of Canadian history and uphold their commitment to complete this investigation over the coming weeks - bringing to light the full truth of this loss.'

LATEST NEWS

Thus far, we have looked at the initial communications strategies effected by both Indigenous and Settler entities during the early days of the news of the unmarked sites at Kamloops.

Over the past two years, however, much of the same communications strategy has been seen and the press releases first looked at are a great representation of the values and ethics of either side. The most recent communications products available to the public come in the form of two reports that were mentioned earlier in this analysis. One is by the Office of the Independent Special Interlocutor and was published in June/July of 2023. The other is an Update by the Assembly of First Nations. These documents are highly valuable as they summarize the current efforts that have been made in tandem with the government for reconciliation, updates on the status of the Kamloops residential school site as well as providing a plethora of recommendations/calls to action going forward.

OSI Interim Report

The Office of the Special Interlocutor (OSI) for Missing Children and Unmarked Burials released a report in June 2023 detailing their progress in investigating unmarked burial sites at former residential schools in Canada.

In general, the OSI's report prioritizes transparency, it outlines the OSI's mandate, investigation methods, and the preliminary findings clearly and concisely. Specific details like the number of communities engaged, over 130, and the utilization of search technologies (ground-penetrating radar, archival research, etc.) provide accountability and allow readers to understand the scope of the investigation at the site of the former Kamloops residential school. For instance, the report states:

"We have partnered with forensic anthropologists and archaeologists to ensure a culturally sensitive and scientifically rigorous approach."

The specific inclusion of this line demonstrates an awareness of the potential sensitivities around human remains and the importance of respectful handling. However, transparency needs to be balanced with sensitivity. While factual reporting forms the backbone of the document, the report also acknowledges the emotional weight of the investigation. For example, terms like "unspeakable loss" and "traumatic experiences" convey respect for survivors and impacted communities.

The report's credibility is further bolstered by its commitment to inclusivity through the elevation and vital inclusion of Indigenous voices. For example, the report highlights the opinions and perspectives of community leaders and Elders. They include a variety of quotes such as:

"It is essential for our youth to know who we are – the raw, real history. Knowing where you come from and putting context into why our families are in the situations we are in...is essential to building healthy communities... To know where we are going, we must first know where we have been." - Stephanie Nirlungakuk, Inuk Youth, National Gathering in Toronto.

While the report offers a well-structured and informative narrative, it does have limitations regarding accessibility. The text-heavy format might be challenging for audiences with visual impairments or those who prefer alternative information formats. To enhance inclusivity and reach a broader audience, the OSI could consider incorporating several strategies. As an example, they could create audio versions of the report, which would provide greater accessibility for individuals with visual

impairments. The OSI might consider creating a plain-language summary. This would condense the information and would broaden the reach of the product. Finally, they might consider including more visual aids. For example, they could display the locations of investigated sites and provide infographics summarizing key statistics.

Ultimately, the OSI's report serves as an important step in disseminating information about the ongoing investigations. Building on these strengths, the OSI could further enhance its communication by incorporating accessible formats and visual aids. Additionally, the report could benefit from outlining a concrete timeline for future updates and findings. Managing public expectations through a clear timeline would foster a sense of continued engagement with the investigation's progress. This information could be included in the document itself or made readily available on the OSI's website alongside the report.

AFN December Update

In December of last year, the Assembly of First Nations released an internal update to their stakeholders about the ongoing concerns related to residential schools and the continued discovery of unmarked burial sites. The report discusses the efforts of the AFN to locate these graves and hold those responsible accountable. Most importantly, it provides an update on the finding of remains at the former Kamloops residential school.

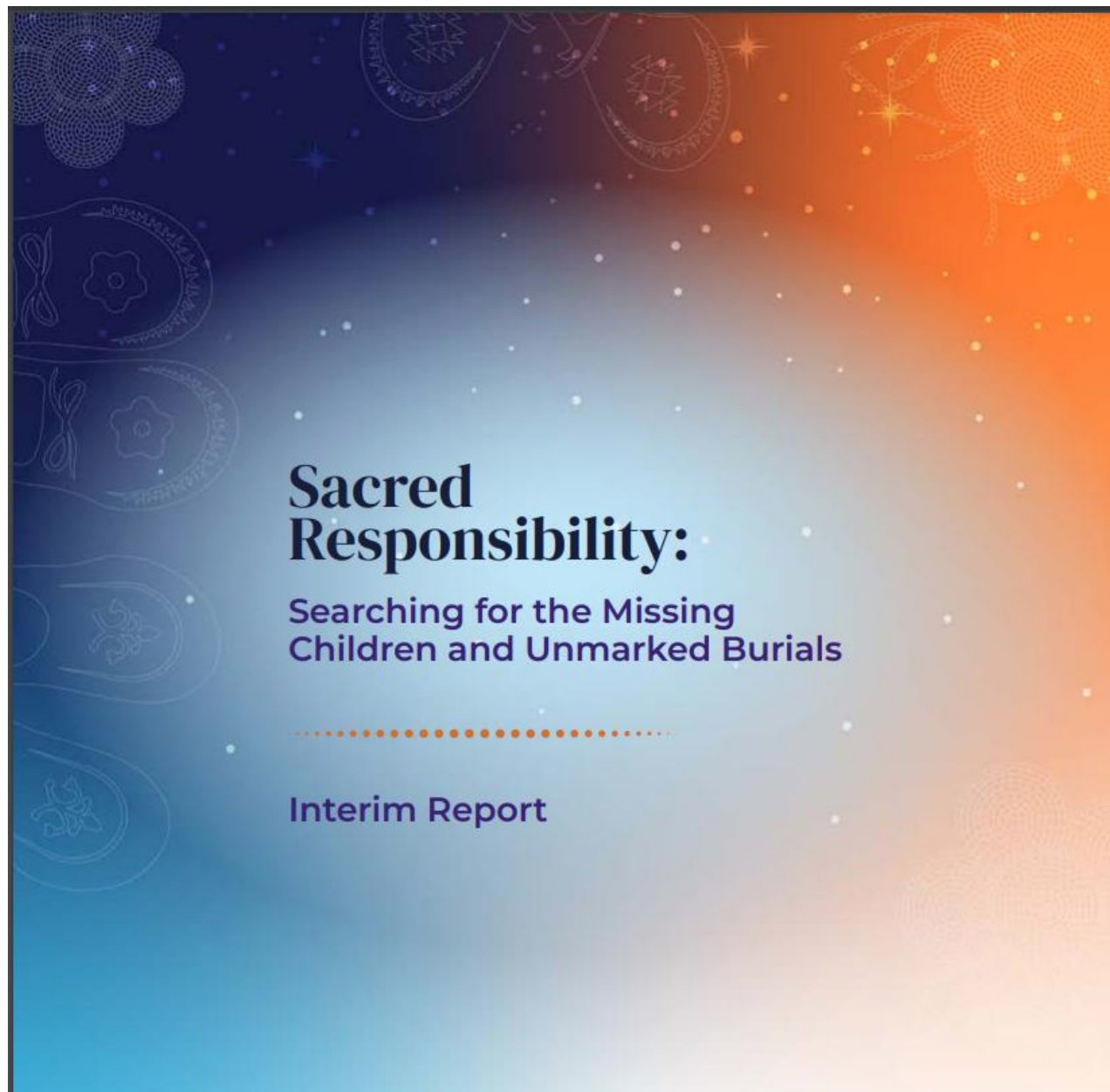
The AFN's report is framed as a unified voice for Indigenous people. It shares the concerns identified by survivors, families and communities. For example, it mentions concerns surrounding the implementation of Calls to Action 71-76 from the Truth and Reconciliation Commission's Final Report. These Calls to Action specifically address missing children and burial information. By focusing on these shared concerns, the document lays the groundwork for collective action and advocacy efforts. This is also evident in its constant use of terms like "common concerns" and "First Nations" concerns. The report places a lot of emphasis on these calls to action and details how the AFN can maintain the government accountable: facilitating implementation, monitoring progress and providing financial summaries through reports/memos.

While the report effectively raises awareness and highlights key concerns, its call to action could be further strengthened. Specifically, the document could benefit from two things. One, clearer calls to action for the public and two, detailed strategies for ongoing engagement. In terms of the first, though the Update primarily focuses on government accountability it would greatly benefit from a broader approach, such as including specific calls to action for the public. For example, they could encourage participation in commemorative events or to support Indigenous-led initiatives. For the second, it would be beneficial to outline additional strategies for ongoing engagement with survivors, families, and communities. This would demonstrate a commitment to not only securing funding but also sustaining efforts towards meaningful action.

Overall, both documents were quite similar in terms of content and presentation. They follow the same characteristics of other Indigenous media and communications products that have already been looked at. Though they provide excellent information and are vital updates, several questions are still left unanswered. Namely, the current status of the 215 unmarked graves. In every report that I have read by both Indigenous and Settler entities, the research and study of the Kamloops site starts and stops at the use of ground-penetrating radar. According to Dr. Sarah Beaulieu and her July 2021 summary report, the team utilized ground-penetrating as the tool to confirm and conclude the location of 215 unmarked graves. Every report states the same, however, no report details as to why the site has not been excavated. No other reports detail other methods utilized, and no other research teams or Knowledge Keepers have been invited to survey the site. Furthermore,

government authorities and other NGOs have also not been allowed on the grounds of the Kamloops site.

With that said, I believe all parties could demonstrate greater transparency in the matter and should release an explanation as to why the site has not been excavated. Equally, I believe for posterity and greater credibility, that the site should be again surveyed by another team, upon invitation and request by the local Indigenous communities. Furthermore, and as an aside, Indigenous authorities and entities should present financial breakdowns and explanations as to how the promised funding has been used or if it has even been released, to begin with.



INTERVIEWS: STRATEGY & OBSTACLES

I began this project to meet or interview several key individuals to better analyze how Settler and Indigenous entities have applied crisis communications strategies. I chose initially to reach out to the following: the Office of the British Columbia Premier, Dr. Sarah Beaulieu of the University of Fraser Valley, as well as the University's Comms department, Indigenous and Northern Affairs Canada and the Office of the Independent Special Interlocutor.

I reached out to these individuals through email throughout the last weeks of February and throughout March. I requested to meet to discuss my communications analysis of the handling of the Kamloops news but also and primarily to answer a few questions regarding a two-year update as to the site and promises made by both sides during the last couple of years.

To summarize, I received no answer from the Premier's office or Dr. Sarah Beaulieu. The University of Fraser Valley did finally reach out the first week of April but referred to their July 2021 report which summarized their initial findings. I received similar answers from Indigenous and Northern Affairs Canada and the OSI, which referred me to the June Interim report as well as the Assembly of First Nations. Overall, it was exceedingly hard to get an interview and I ultimately failed in this task.

Going forward, in order to answer some questions and other inquiries that were left unresolved, interviews with experts and with representatives from Indigenous communities would be extremely vital to provide more information. It would also give my project a greater scope in terms of some of the ethical questions that are raised in the development of communications strategies when faced with similar tragedies.

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Government of Canada enhances support to Indigenous communities to respond to and heal from the ongoing impacts of residential schools

From: [Crown-Indigenous Relations and Northern Affairs Canada](#)

News release

August, 10, 2021 — Ottawa, traditional territory of the Algonquin Anishinaabeg Nation, Ontario — Crown-Indigenous Relations and Northern Affairs Canada

The Government of Canada is taking further action to enhance support for Indigenous Peoples and communities as they continue to respond to and heal from the intergenerational trauma of residential schools. Canada is listening and will continue to listen to First Nations, Inuit and Métis Survivors and their families. In order to create a historical record of children who did not return home from residential schools, Canada continues to support communities as they locate burial sites and commemorate and memorialize the innocent lost lives.

Today, the Honourable Carolyn Bennett, Minister of Crown-Indigenous

CONCLUSIONS & RECOMMENDATIONS

To conclude this report, the news of the Kamloops Residential School was a major event in modern Canadian history. It flipped the table on conversations regarding reconciliation and made Canadian society aware as a whole of the tremendous issues that are ongoing to Settler-Indigenous relations. Besides being a major historical event, it was also a huge event for the Communications world and would have been a nightmare for those in government comms.

For the rest of us, it acts as a great means to analyze the current communications 'best' practices currently affected by Settler and Indigenous communities. This report set out to look at just that and compare the differences in messaging and generally how either side chose to frame the crisis.

Key Takeaways

As a result, I developed five key takeaways from this report, and these can be summarized as follows:

- 1) The discovery forced Canadians to confront the dark history of residential schools and its impact on Indigenous communities. It sparked national outrage, media coverage, and international attention and resulted in major national/societal changes.
- 2) The Canadian government responded with financial commitments, a National Day for Truth and Reconciliation, and initiatives to support survivors. However, concerns remain about the pace of reconciliation efforts, and these have been highlighted in recent reports from last year.
- 3) Settler entities initially focused on factual details, historical context, and emotional weight. Press releases were structured similarly - acknowledging the tragedy, historical context, support offered, and resources available. While both sides acknowledged the tragedy, Indigenous media used a victim-centred approach, focusing on the human cost and ongoing trauma. Settler media was more objective and impersonal.
- 4) The crisis led to a renewed focus on commitments between governments and Indigenous communities. New positions and commissions were created to support ongoing efforts.
- 5) Legal limitations and a lack of resources continue to hinder efforts to identify and protect unmarked graves, as detailed in the OSI and AFN reports. Furthermore, the final status of the Kamloops site remains unclear, with no updates on further investigations.

Comms Recommendations

Now, in terms of communications strategy and recommendations going forward. I believe there are several ways that both Settler and Indigenous media can greatly improve their messaging. Ultimately, the main issues I found related to transparency and details – often insufficient information is provided, and no other resources are given if a person is willing to learn more. Here are three recommendations that either side should take into account if ever there is another event as tragic and explosive as this:

- 1) A greater emphasis on detail should be placed on communications items. If funding is mentioned, a breakdown and precise use should be available to the public. Equally, any reports by Indigenous media should mention in detail how funding has been distributed or if it has been received.

- 2) Government communications products should modify their tone and language and should instead use a less formal and more colloquial voice. Often the extreme formality of the government detracts from the emotional weight of the given subject. They should look to engage in genuine dialogue with Indigenous voices.
- 3) Reports and other communications products must present concrete plans on promises made. A roadmap should be available to the public on how the government and other Settler entities plan to collaborate with Indigenous communities or to demonstrate how funding will be used.

By following these recommendations not only will Settler and Indigenous entities achieve a broader communication strategy, but it would also directly benefit Indigenous-Settler relations and would generally demonstrate a stronger commitment to reconciliation. Though much has been done in the last two years since the announcement of this tragedy, a lot more remains to be seen and we can also do better to improve our communications practices.



British Columbia

\$2.8-billion settlement reached in class action lawsuit over residential schools

Suit was filed in 2012 over destruction of language and culture caused by residential school system

CBC News · Posted: Jan 21, 2023 12:27 PM EST | Last Updated: January 21, 2023



A memorial outside the former Kamloops Indian Residential School in 2021. The federal government has agreed to settle a class-action lawsuit over the loss of culture and language brought on by Indian residential schools for \$2.8 billion. (Ben Nelms/CBC)

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